SULFASALAZINE

Orange urine & contact lenses
CBC & LFT monitoring

CHEMICAL NAME 2-hydroxy-5-[(E)-2-{4-[(pyridin-2-yl)sulfamoyl]phenyl}diazen-1-yl]benzoic acid (salicylazosulfapyridine)
CLASS Aminosalicylate prodrug (5-ASA + sulfapyridine); DMARD
TRADE NAMES Salazopyrin · Azulfidine · Salazopyrin EN-tabs

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Ulcerative colitis (induction and maintenance).
- Crohn's colitis.
- Rheumatoid arthritis (DMARD, alone or with methotrexate); psoriatic arthritis, ankylosing spondylitis (peripheral).

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** after food with water; enteric-coated tablets swallowed whole.
- Increase dose gradually to reduce GI upset.
- **PR** suppositories/enemas.

DOSAGES

- **UC active:** 1–2 g four times daily; maintenance 500 mg four times daily.
- **Rheumatoid arthritis (EN):** 500 mg daily, increase weekly to 2–3 g/day in divided doses.
- **Children (UC):** 40–60 mg/kg/day divided.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- Partially absorbed; split by colonic bacteria into **5-ASA** (acts locally) and **sulfapyridine** (absorbed, acetylated in liver — slow acetylators ↑ side effects).
- Excreted in urine. **t½:** 5–10 h.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- CBC and LFTs every 2 weeks for 3 months, then monthly for 3 months, then 3-monthly.
- Renal function periodically.
- Folic acid supplementation may be needed.
- Report sore throat, fever, mouth ulcers, bruising.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- 5-ASA: local anti-inflammatory in colon.
- Sulfapyridine and parent drug: immunomodulatory effects (↓ cytokines) in arthritis.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Nausea, anorexia, headache.
- Orange-yellow urine, sweat, tears (stains soft contact lenses).
- Rash; oligospermia (reversible male infertility).

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Blood dyscrasias (agranulocytosis, megaloblastic anaemia from folate deficiency, haemolysis in G6PD deficiency).
- Hepatotoxicity.
- SJS/TEN, DRESS.
- Pulmonary fibrosis; pancreatitis (rare).

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Sulfonamide or salicylate hypersensitivity.
- Porphyria.
- Children <2 yr.
- **Caution:** G6PD deficiency, renal/hepatic impairment.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Digoxin, folic acid:** ↓ absorption.
- **Azathioprine, methotrexate:** ↑ myelosuppression.
- **Warfarin:** altered INR.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Take after food with water.
- Urine and tears may turn orange — avoid soft contact lenses.
- Report sore throat, fever, bruising, rash or yellow skin immediately.
- Men: may reduce sperm count (reversible).

KEY POINTS

- Prodrug of 5-ASA + sulfapyridine.
- Orange body fluids.
- UC and rheumatoid arthritis.
- Blood monitoring for dyscrasias and liver.